PADHAKU
Democratic Politics · Class 10 Social Science

CHAPTER 4

Political Parties

NCERT Exercise Solutions

Think · Why do we need political parties?	1 Q
Activity · Functions of political parties (photographs)	1 Q
Activity · Party systems in the States	1 Q
Crunching the Numbers · Popular participation in political parties	1 Q
Think · Challenges to political parties	3 Q
Think · How can parties be reformed?	1 Q
Exercises	14 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

Independent study aid by Beginers Point. Not an official NCERT publication.

🤔 Think · Why do we need political parties?

? **Okay, granted that we can't live without political parties. But tell me on what grounds do people support a political party?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

People support a party on these grounds:

- **Policies and programmes:** they agree with what the party promises for society.
- **Interests:** the party stands for their part of society (e.g. farmers, workers, dalits, a region).
- **Leaders:** they trust or admire the party's leaders.
- **Ideology:** they share its ideas (e.g. secularism, socialism, cultural nationalism).
- **Access and work:** local party leaders help them reach government offices and welfare schemes.
- **Past record:** the party's work when it was in government or opposition.

Activity · Functions of political parties (photographs)

? **Categorise these photographs by the functions of political parties they illustrate. Find one photograph or news clipping from your own area for each of the functions listed above.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Photograph	Function of parties
1. BJP Mahila Morcha activists protest against price rise of onions and LPG	Shaping public opinion: raising issues and launching movements; also acting as opposition
2. Minister gives ₹ One lakh cheque to families of hooch victims	Forming and running governments; giving people access to government welfare schemes
3. CPI (M), CPI, OGP and JD (S) rally against POSCO exporting iron ore	Playing the role of opposition and mobilising people against a government decision

Own area: collect local newspaper photos, e.g. a party campaign during elections (contesting elections), a manifesto (policies), an assembly debate (making laws), a party-led protest (opposition / public opinion).

Activity · Party systems in the States

? **Here are three major types of party systems that exist at the State level. Can you find the names of at least two States for each type? Two-party system; Multiparty system with two alliances; Multiparty system.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Type	Example States
Two-party system	Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh (contest mainly between BJP and INC)
Multiparty system with two alliances	Kerala (LDF vs UDF), Tamil Nadu (DMK-led vs AIADMK-led alliances)
Multiparty system	Uttar Pradesh (BJP, SP, BSP, INC), Punjab (AAP, INC, SAD, BJP)

Note: party systems change over time; check the latest election results.

Crunching the Numbers · Popular participation in political parties

? **Does the cartoon reflect the data graphics shown on the previous page?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes, partly.

- The cartoon shows that only 27% and 35% of Canadians support the two main parties, while 98% want all politicians 'locked in a car going over Niagara Falls'.
- This matches the data: political parties are among the **least trusted** institutions in South Asia and the world (37% great/some trust, 43% not much/none in South Asia).
- But the data also shows something the cartoon does not: people still **take part** in parties. Party membership and closeness to parties have gone up in India, and membership in India (11.4%) is higher than in Canada (6.1%).

🤔 Think · Challenges to political parties

? Why don't parties give enough tickets to women? Is that also due to lack of internal democracy?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, to a large extent.

- Ticket decisions are taken by a few top leaders, not by open, democratic procedures inside the party.
- Parties prefer candidates who have money, connections or are close to the leader; women often lack these.
- Ordinary members, including women workers, cannot influence such decisions.

- That is why a suggested reform is to make it **mandatory to give about one-third of tickets** to women and a quota in party decision-making bodies.

? Does this suggest that in democracies people contest elections only to make money? But isn't it true that there are politicians committed to the well-being of the people?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- No. The cartoon only highlights a real problem: the growing role of **money power**; rich people get tickets and some see politics as a way to gain more.
- It is true that there are many politicians who work honestly for the people, raise their problems and fight for their rights.
- So we should not condemn all politicians; instead we should support honest leaders and reform the system to reduce money and muscle power.

? Can you identify which of the challenges described in this section are being highlighted in these cartoons (on pages 57 to 59)? What are the ways to curb the misuse of money and muscle power in politics?

✔ ANSWER

Challenges in the cartoons:

- **Berlusconi Puppet Theatre (p. 57):** a rich businessman-leader controls the party and the media like a puppet master: lack of internal democracy (one leader dominates) and the role of money power.
- **Corporate America cartoon (p. 58):** big companies control the ruling party and institutions: growing role of money power / rich companies in politics.
- **'You already have so much money...' (p. 59):** rich people get tickets and contest elections: money power in elections.

Ways to curb money and muscle power:

- Candidates must file an **affidavit** about property and criminal cases (already done); the information should be checked.
- **State funding of elections** (in kind or cash) so parties depend less on rich donors.
- Strict limits on election spending and open accounts of party funds.
- Parties should not give tickets to people with criminal records.
- Voters, media and pressure groups should expose and reject such candidates.

🤔 Think · How can parties be reformed?

? Do you agree that this form of reforming political parties will be acceptable to them? (Cartoon: party leaders say "Electoral discipline is not our cup of tea")

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

No, not easily.

- The cartoon shows party leaders refusing the Election Commission's demand for discipline.
- Reforms like internal elections, filing tax returns or women's quota reduce the power of top leaders, so parties resist them; many do internal elections only as a formality.
- Laws are made by the same party leaders, so they will not pass laws they dislike.
- So pressure from citizens, media and movements, and participation of good people in parties, are also needed.

📝 Exercises

1 State the various functions political parties perform in a democracy.

✔ ANSWER

Political parties fill political offices and exercise political power. Their functions are:

1. **Contest elections:** they put up candidates (in India, top leaders choose candidates).

2. **Put forward policies and programmes:** they group many opinions into a few basic positions and voters choose from them.

3. **Make laws:** most legislators belong to parties and follow the party leadership.

4. **Form and run governments:** they recruit and train leaders and make them ministers.

5. **Play the role of opposition:** losing parties criticise the government's failures and wrong policies and mobilise opposition.

6. **Shape public opinion:** they raise issues and launch movements to solve people's problems.

7. **Give access to government machinery and welfare schemes:** it is easier to approach a local party leader than a government officer.

Thus parties are a necessary condition for a democracy.

2 **What are the various challenges faced by political parties?**

✔ ANSWER

Popular criticism of parties focuses on four challenges:

1. **Lack of internal democracy:** power is concentrated in one or a few top leaders; no membership registers, meetings or regular internal elections; ordinary members cannot influence decisions; personal loyalty to the leader matters more than party principles.

2. **Dynastic succession:** top positions are controlled by members of one family; ordinary workers cannot rise to the top; people without experience or popular support get power.

3. **Growing role of money and muscle power:** parties give tickets to those who have or can raise lots of money; rich people and companies influence party policies; sometimes parties support criminals who can win.

4. **No meaningful choice for voters:** ideological differences among parties have declined (e.g. Labour and Conservative in Britain; economic policies of Indian parties); the same leaders keep shifting from one party to another.

Parties must overcome these to remain effective instruments of democracy.

3 **Suggest some reforms to strengthen parties so that they perform their functions well.**

✔ ANSWER

Some reforms already made and some suggested:

1. **Anti-defection law:** the Constitution was amended so an MLA or MP who changes party loses the seat.

2. **Affidavits:** the Supreme Court made it mandatory for every candidate to give details of property and pending criminal cases.

3. **Organisational elections and tax returns:** the Election Commission made it necessary for parties to hold internal elections and file income tax returns.

4. **Law on internal affairs:** parties should keep a register of members, follow their own constitution, have an independent authority to settle disputes and hold open elections to top posts.

5. **Tickets for women:** about one-third of tickets to women and a quota for women in party decision-making bodies.

6. **State funding of elections:** in kind (petrol, paper, telephone) or in cash based on votes in the last election.

7. **People's pressure and participation:** petitions, publicity and agitations by citizens, pressure groups, movements and the media; and good people joining parties.

Over-regulation should be avoided, as parties may find ways to cheat the law.

4 **What is a political party?**

✔ ANSWER

A political party is a **group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in the government**.

They agree on some policies and programmes for society with a view to promote the collective good, and try to win popular support for them through elections.

5 **What are the characteristics of a political party?**

✔ ANSWER

- It is a group of people who agree on certain policies and programmes for the collective good of society.
- It contests elections to win power and form the government.
- It tries to persuade people that its policies are better than those of others.
- It reflects fundamental political divisions in society; it stands for a part of society and involves **partisanship**.
- It is known by which part it stands for, which policies it supports and whose interests it upholds.
- It has three components: **the leaders, the active members and the followers**.

6 A group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in the government is called a _____.

✔ ANSWER

Political party.

7 Match List I with List II and select the correct answer:

List I	List II
1. Congress Party	A. National Democratic Alliance
2. Bharatiya Janata Party	B. State party
3. Communist Party of India (Marxist)	C. United Progressive Alliance
4. Telugu Desam Party	D. Left Front

(a) C A B D (b) C D A B (c) C A D B (d) D C A B

✔ ANSWER

(c) C A D B

Congress led the UPA, BJP leads the NDA, CPI (M) is part of the Left Front, and the Telugu Desam Party is a State party.

8 Who among the following is the founder of the Bahujan Samaj Party? A. Kanshi Ram B. Sahu Maharaj C. B.R. Ambedkar D. Jotiba Phule

✔ ANSWER

A. Kanshi Ram

The BSP was formed in 1984 under his leadership; the others were sources of inspiration.

9 **What is the guiding philosophy of the Bharatiya Janata Party? A. Bahujan Samaj B. Revolutionary democracy C. Integral humanism D. Modernity**

✔ ANSWER

C. Integral humanism

The BJP draws inspiration from Deendayal Upadhyaya's ideas of integral humanism and Antyodaya.

10 **Consider the following statements on parties.**

A. Political parties do not enjoy much trust among the people.

B. Parties are often rocked by scandals involving top party leaders.

C. Parties are not necessary to run governments.

Which are correct? (a) A, B and C (b) A and B (c) B and C (d) A and C

✔ ANSWER

(b) A and B

C is wrong: parties form and run governments and are a necessary condition for democracy.

11 (a) **Read the passage: Muhammad Yunus, Nobel Peace Prize winner (2006) of Bangladesh, launched a new party, Nagarik Shakti (Citizens' Power), in February 2007 to foster proper leadership, good governance and a new political culture, democratic from the grassroots. Some welcomed it; leaders of traditional parties were apprehensive; some asked if he was planted by mentors from outside the country.**

Do you think Yunus made a right decision to float a new political party?

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes, it was a right decision.

- In a democracy any group of citizens is free to form a political party.
- He wanted good governance, honest leadership and a party democratic from the grassroots, which traditional parties lacked.
- A new party gives voters a **meaningful choice** and can push other parties to improve.
- As the chapter says, the problem of bad politics can be solved by more and better politics: good people joining politics.

11 (b) **Do you agree with the statements and fears expressed by various people?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Shahedul Islam's hope** (a chance to choose between good and bad, fight against corruption and black money) is reasonable: a new clean party can offer a real choice.
- **The BNP leader's view** that politics is different and challenging is partly true, but it should not stop an honest person from entering politics.
- **The fear that he was 'planted' by outside mentors** has no evidence in the passage; it looks like a tactic of rivals who feel threatened.

So I agree with the hopeful view and do not agree with the baseless fears.

11 (c) **How do you want this new party organised to make it different from other parties?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Internal democracy:** a register of members, regular meetings and open elections to all posts.
- **No dynastic succession:** ordinary workers can rise to the top.
- **Clean funding:** transparent accounts; no tickets to rich or criminal candidates only for winning.

- **Tickets and posts for women** (about one-third) and weaker sections.
- **Clear policies** that offer a real choice, decided with members' participation.
- An independent authority inside the party to settle disputes.

11 (d) **If you were the one to begin this political party, how would you defend it?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Every citizen has the democratic right to form a party and contest elections.
- The party is needed because existing parties lack internal democracy, are dynastic and influenced by money and muscle power.
- Its aim is good governance, fighting corruption and black money, and development of the poor, as shown by my past work.
- It is organised democratically from the grassroots, so people themselves run it.
- It is funded openly by citizens, not by foreign mentors; the people can judge it in the elections.

🎉 **Chapter 4 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**